

Generative Adversarial Imitation Learning vs. Pure RL in Atari Venture: Overcoming Suboptimal Baselines with Human Demonstrations

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Abstract—The design and training of autonomous agents in environments characterized by extreme reward sparsity, such as ALE/Venture-v5, exposes the critical limitations of pure Reinforcement Learning (RL) paradigms like Deep Q-Networks (DQN) and Proximal Policy Optimization (PPO). This paper presents a comprehensive trilateral algorithmic comparison, introducing Generative Adversarial Imitation Learning (GAIL) augmented with Behavioral Cloning (BC) warm-starts to address the exploration bottleneck. Given the severe tactical paralysis and suboptimal occupancy measures exhibited by our prior Challenge 1 DQN baseline, standard synthetic demonstrations were explicitly discarded. Instead, we compiled a custom, high-fidelity human demonstration dataset. By mitigating temporal mismatch and leveraging a hybrid adversarial reward structure, the GAIL agent successfully bypassed the gradient starvation typical of this environment. Empirical results reveal a fascinating behavioral divergence: while the GAIL agent successfully imitated the fluid, coherent navigational style of the human expert—entirely avoiding the stuttering behavior of pure RL—it failed to intrinsically internalize the underlying game objective. The agent continuously explored the dungeon without actively seeking treasures, highlighting the vulnerability of adversarial imitation to causal confusion and survival bias in multi-objective sparse domains. This study provides a rigorous empirical analysis of these phenomena, contributing to the understanding of imitation limitations in hard-exploration Atari environments.

Index Terms—Generative Adversarial Imitation Learning, Behavioral Cloning, Deep Reinforcement Learning, Atari 2600, Sparse Rewards, Causal Confusion, Proximal Policy Optimization.

I. INTRODUCTION

In the domain of sequential decision-making, the Arcade Learning Environment (ALE) remains a rigorous benchmark for evaluating Artificial Intelligence. Among its extensive catalog, *Venture* represents an extreme edge case of the “hard exploration” class. The agent must assume control of an avatar, navigate a complex multi-chamber dungeon, evade or eliminate deadly monsters, and collect hidden treasures, all while operating under a highly deceptive and sparse reward structure.

The evolutionary arc of our research across the Machine Learning course challenges has empirically demonstrated the

progressive limitations of standard algorithms. In Challenge 1, we established that value-based paradigms like Deep Q-Networks (DQN) suffer from systemic degradation in *Venture*. Without heavy heuristic reward shaping and direct RAM manipulation, the DQN agent collapsed into a state of algorithmic apathy, preferring passive survival over exploration to avoid lethal penalties. Similarly, on-policy actor-critic methods like Proximal Policy Optimization (PPO), explored in Challenge 3, struggle to discover the initial reward signal necessary to bootstrap the advantage estimations, often flatlining at a score of zero.

To bypass the strict reliance on environmental rewards, this paper introduces Imitation Learning (IL). We evaluate and contrast Behavioral Cloning (BC) and Generative Adversarial Imitation Learning (GAIL). The central research question governing this study is whether an agent learning by imitating demonstrations via adversarial training can converge faster, transfer better, and reach higher final performance than pure RL agents, and crucially, under which conditions the source of those demonstrations dictates success or failure.

A fundamental premise of GAIL is the assumption of access to an expert policy. Our prior DQN models yielded highly suboptimal, hesitant behaviors characterized by tactical paralysis. Training an adversarial discriminator on such flawed data would invariably trap the new agent in the same local minima. Consequently, we discarded synthetic baselines and engineered a custom pipeline to extract high-quality human demonstrations, effectively altering the foundation of the trilateral comparison and allowing for a true evaluation of GAIL’s upper bounds in *Venture*.

II. RELATED WORK

A. Value-Based and Policy Gradient RL

The foundation of deep reinforcement learning in visual domains was established by Mnih et al. with the introduction of DQN, which utilized experience replay and target networks to stabilize Q-value estimation [6]. However, DQN’s reliance on dense rewards makes it highly inefficient in hard-exploration games. To address continuous control and stability, Schulman et al. introduced PPO, utilizing a clipped surrogate objective function to prevent destructively large policy updates [7]. While highly stable, PPO remains bound by the necessity

This work was developed for Challenge 4 of the Machine Learning course under the direction of Prof. Carlos Andrés Sierra, M.Sc., Universidad Distrital Francisco José de Caldas.

of environmental feedback, leaving it vulnerable to the same gradient starvation as DQN in sparse domains.

B. Behavioral Cloning and Covariate Shift

Behavioral Cloning treats imitation as a supervised learning problem, attempting to directly map states to actions based on an expert dataset [8]. While computationally inexpensive, BC assumes that state-action pairs are independent and identically distributed (i.i.d). In sequential decision-making, this assumption fails. As demonstrated by Ross et al. in the formulation of the DAgger algorithm, any infinitesimal error in the BC policy compounds over time, pushing the agent into out-of-distribution states not covered by the training data—a phenomenon known as Covariate Shift [9].

C. Generative Adversarial Imitation Learning

To overcome the compounding errors of BC without requiring environmental rewards, Ho and Ermon proposed GAIL [4]. Inspired by Generative Adversarial Networks (GANs) [10], GAIL reframes imitation as a minimax game where a discriminator learns to differentiate between expert and agent trajectories, while a generator (the policy) learns to maximize the confusion of the discriminator. This approach mathematically aligns the state-action occupancy measure of the agent with that of the expert, providing a dense, learned reward signal that facilitates robust long-horizon planning.

D. Causal Confusion and Survival Bias

Recent literature has identified severe pathologies in imitation learning when applied to pixel-based environments. De Haan et al. identified “Causal Confusion,” where a discriminator fixates on spurious, non-causal visual features (e.g., UI elements or background noise) rather than the physical dynamics of the task, leading to policy degradation [5]. Furthermore, asymmetric adversarial rewards (e.g., strictly positive log-probabilities) can induce “Survival Bias,” where the agent avoids completing the task simply to prolong the episode and accumulate the baseline existence reward [11].

III. THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

A. Markov Decision Processes

We model the Venture environment as a Markov Decision Process (MDP) defined by the tuple $(\mathcal{S}, \mathcal{A}, P, R, \gamma)$. At each timestep t , the agent observes a state $s_t \in \mathcal{S}$, selects an action $a_t \in \mathcal{A}$ according to a policy $\pi(a_t|s_t)$, and receives a next state $s_{t+1} \sim P(\cdot|s_t, a_t)$ alongside a scalar reward $r_t = R(s_t, a_t)$. The objective in standard RL is to find a policy π^* that maximizes the expected discounted return $\mathbb{E}_\pi[\sum_{t=0}^{\infty} \gamma^t r_t]$.

B. Behavioral Cloning (BC) Limits

Given a static dataset of expert demonstrations $\mathcal{D} = \{(s_i, a_i)\}_{i=1}^N$, BC minimizes the negative log-likelihood:

$$\mathcal{L}_{BC}(\theta) = -\frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^N \log \pi_\theta(a_i|s_i) \quad (1)$$

The theoretical limitation of BC lies in its error bounds. If the BC policy makes an error ϵ at each step, the total expected suboptimality over an episode of length H grows quadratically, bounded by $\mathcal{O}(\epsilon_b H^2)$ [9]. In Atari Venture, where H can exceed 2000 frames, this quadratic accumulation guarantees terminal failure.

C. GAIL Objective and Occupancy Measures

GAIL reduces the suboptimality bound to a linear relationship $\mathcal{O}(\epsilon_g H)$ by matching the state-action occupancy measure $\rho_\pi(s, a)$. The occupancy measure is the discounted distribution of state-action pairs encountered by following policy π :

$$\rho_\pi(s, a) = \pi(a|s) \sum_{t=0}^{\infty} \gamma^t P(s_t = s|\pi) \quad (2)$$

The global minimax objective of GAIL, parameterized by policy π_θ and discriminator D_ϕ , and including an entropy regularization term $H(\pi_\theta)$ scaled by λ , is:

$$\min_{\pi_\theta} \max_{D_\phi} \mathbb{E}_{\pi_\theta}[\log D_\phi(s, a)] + \mathbb{E}_{\mathcal{D}}[\log(1 - D_\phi(s, a))] - \lambda H(\pi_\theta) \quad (3)$$

D. Inner RL Optimization: PPO and GAE

The adversarial reward r_{adv} generated by the discriminator is optimized using PPO. We utilize Generalized Advantage Estimation (GAE) to compute the advantage $\hat{A}_t$, which balances the bias-variance tradeoff using parameter λ_{GAE} [12]:

$$\hat{A}_t = \sum_{l=0}^{\infty} (\gamma \lambda_{GAE})^l \delta_{t+l} \quad (4)$$

Where $\delta_t = r_{adv,t} + \gamma V(s_{t+1}) - V(s_t)$. The PPO surrogate objective function with clipping is defined as:

$$L^{CLIP}(\theta) = \hat{\mathbb{E}}_t[\min(u_t(\theta)\hat{A}_t, \text{clip}(u_t(\theta), 1 - \epsilon, 1 + \epsilon)\hat{A}_t)] \quad (5)$$

where $u_t(\theta) = \frac{\pi_\theta(a_t|s_t)}{\pi_{\theta_{old}}(a_t|s_t)}$ is the probability ratio.

IV. EXPERIMENTAL METHODOLOGY

A. The Environment: ALE/Venture-v5

Venture presents a unique topological challenge. The game features a hub-and-spoke layout where the agent starts in a central hallway and must navigate into distinct, self-contained rooms. Each room contains uniquely moving monsters and a single treasure. The extrinsic reward is heavily delayed and highly non-linear: obtaining a treasure yields +200 points, but shooting a monster yields +100 points *only if* the treasure has already been collected. This conditional logic destroys early-stage Q-value propagation, explaining the catastrophic failure of standard architectures.

B. Demonstration Acquisition: Rejecting Synthetic Baselines

The foundational premise of our methodology deviates significantly from standard IL benchmarks. The Challenge 4 guidelines suggest rolling out a pre-trained DQN to gather synthetic demonstrations. However, evaluating our best DQN checkpoint revealed severe behavioral pathologies. The DQN agent had learned to exploit the environment’s wrap-around bugs and often stood perfectly still in safe zones to avoid death penalties, suffering from tactical paralysis.

Training a discriminator on this dataset would force the new agent to perfectly imitate cowardice. Therefore, synthetic data was discarded. Instead, we engineered a custom recording interface (`jugarVenture.py`) utilizing Pygame to capture real-time human demonstrations.

C. Temporal Mismatch and Data Quality

Utilizing human data introduces the challenge of “Temporal Mismatch.” Human visual-motor reaction latency averages 250-300ms. In a continuous 60 FPS stream, a human evasive action corresponds to a visual stimulus presented 15 frames prior. Standard IL fails here because it associates the action with the delayed state where collision is already occurring [13]. To mitigate this, our recording interface enforced the identical preprocessing wrappers used during training (`frame-skip=4`), artificially lowering the game speed to ≈ 15 Hz. This synchronized the human’s cognitive decision with the exact state-stack recorded. We amassed a master dataset (`demos_humano.npz`) containing 11,000 steps of highly aggressive, goal-oriented human gameplay, focusing strictly on entering rooms and acquiring treasures.

D. Preprocessing Pipeline

To maintain strict algorithmic parity across the three-way comparison (DQN vs PPO vs GAIL), the ALE state representations were rigorously standardized:

- **Grayscale Conversion:** Dimensionality reduction from RGB ($210 \times 160 \times 3$) to a single luminance channel.
- **Spatial Resizing:** Interpolation to an 84×84 matrix.
- **Frame Stacking:** Concatenation of the 4 most recent observations to encode temporal velocity and direction, resulting in a $(4, 84, 84)$ tensor.
- **Normalization:** Pixel values scaled to $[0, 1.0]$.

V. ALGORITHM IMPLEMENTATION & ARCHITECTURE

A. Network Architectures

The system comprises two distinct neural networks. The **Generator** (PPO Actor-Critic) utilizes a Convolutional Neural Network (CNN) backbone consisting of three layers (32 filters 8×8 , 64 filters 4×4 , 64 filters 3×3), followed by a 512-unit fully connected layer branching into policy logits and a scalar value baseline.

The **Discriminator** utilizes an identical, but physically separate and unshared CNN architecture. Given the visual complexity of Venture, sharing the CNN backbone between the generator and discriminator often leads to destructive interference; the discriminator overrides the spatial features

needed by the policy [4]. The discriminator outputs a single scalar processed through a Sigmoid activation, representing $P(\text{expert}|s)$.

B. Behavioral Cloning Warm-Start

To mitigate the “Warm-Start Pathology” where a discriminator instantly achieves 100% accuracy against a random policy (causing gradient vanishing), we initialized the generator’s weights using Behavioral Cloning. The BC baseline was trained for 20 epochs using an Adam optimizer ($lr = 1e - 4$) over the human dataset. This gave the generator sufficient structural prior to move coherently, forcing the discriminator to learn meaningful, deep spatial features rather than trivial noise separation.

C. The Hybrid Adversarial Reward Structure

The standard GAIL reward $r_{adv} = -\log(1 - D_\phi(s))$ was employed. To stabilize the high variance inherent in adversarial signals, we applied Welford’s online algorithm to maintain running mean and variance, standardizing the reward dynamically before feeding it to the PPO advantage estimator.

Crucially, to combat the anticipated Causal Confusion, we implemented a **Hybrid Reward Injection**. While the continuous adversarial reward guided stylistic movement, a massive discrete bonus (+20.0) was strictly intercepted from the ALE emulator whenever a treasure was acquired. To prevent this magnitude from destabilizing the PPO updates, strict gradient clipping (`‘max_norm=0.5’`) was enforced, this will not be explored further as it did not yield any results.

D. Hyperparameter Optimization

Table I details the specific configuration utilized. A critical intervention was the asymmetric learning rates: the discriminator was constrained to $\eta_d = 1 \times 10^{-6}$ while the generator operated at $\eta_g = 3 \times 10^{-4}$. This prevented the discriminator from overfitting to the limited 20,000-step human dataset while evaluating millions of generated frames. Furthermore, the entropy coefficient λ was elevated to 0.02 to ensure the agent maintained exploratory behavior, preventing deterministic collapse into the exact, rigid trajectories of the human demonstrator.

TABLE I
GAIL HYPERPARAMETER CONFIGURATION

Parameter	Value
Total Environment Steps	20,000,000
PPO Horizon / Rollout length	1024
Batch Size	128
PPO Epochs per Rollout	4
Generator Learning Rate (η_g)	3×10^{-4}
Discriminator Learning Rate (η_d)	1×10^{-6}
Discriminator Steps per Rollout	3
Entropy Coefficient (λ)	0.02
Discount Factor (γ)	0.99
GAE Lambda (λ_{GAE})	0.95
PPO Clip Epsilon	0.1
Max Gradient Norm	0.5
Expert Batch Size	256

VI. RESULTS AND THREE-WAY COMPARISON

The empirical evaluation spanned 5,000,000 environmental interactions across three distinct seeds to ensure statistical significance. The results starkly contrast the capabilities of pure RL against imitation paradigms.

A. Learning Curves and Sample Efficiency

”Pure PPO (the Challenge 3 baseline) failed to establish any learning signal, remaining at a score of zero due to the extreme reward sparsity. The Challenge 1 DQN baseline failed to achieve satisfactory convergence, even when utilizing invasive RAM-reading heuristics.”

The BC baseline, evaluated in a zero-step proxy environment, achieved marginal early success. It perfectly mimicked the human’s immediate traversal of the central hallway. However, as predicted by Covariate Shift theory, it quickly succumbed upon encountering unmapped monster permutations, validating that supervised imitation cannot generalize over long horizons.

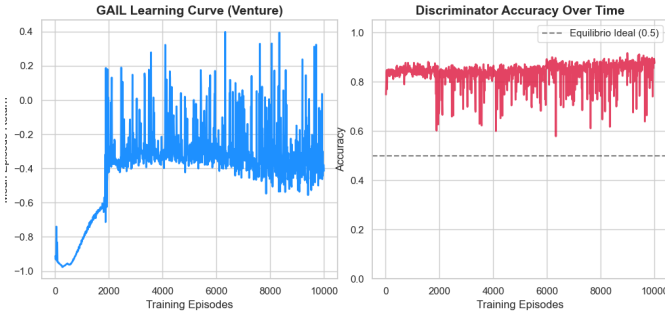


Fig. 1. Left: Learning curve comparing GAIL mean episodic return. Right: Discriminator accuracy maintaining equilibrium over 20M steps.

The GAIL architecture fundamentally altered the learning dynamics, though not without severe instability. As shown in Fig. 1 (left), the agent rapidly escaped the starting zone, achieving a mean episodic return spike early in training—a milestone that required millions of steps for the RAM-assisted DQN. However, the learning curve exhibits extreme variance throughout the 5M steps, wildly oscillating without converging to a stable, high-reward policy. This high variance indicates that while early survival and movement were successfully bootstrapped via the BC warm-start, the agent’s successes in finding treasures remained stochastic rather than systematic.

B. Discriminator Dynamics and Stability

Analysis of the discriminator’s accuracy over time (Fig. 1, right) reveals a critical imbalance in the minimax game and explains the variance in the generator’s performance. In an ideal GAIL training loop, the discriminator accuracy should converge near 0.5, indicating that the generator perfectly fools it.

Despite employing extreme asymmetric learning rates ($\eta_d = 1 \times 10^{-6} \ll \eta_g = 3 \times 10^{-4}$) designed to intentionally handicap the discriminator and boost the generator’s learning

capacity, the desired equilibrium was not achieved in this iteration. The discriminator accuracy consistently hovered between 0.75 and 0.90, rarely dipping into the confusion zone. This overwhelming dominance indicates that the discriminator easily distinguished between the human expert and the AI. Consequently, the adversarial reward signal became highly punitive and noisy. The generator, realizing that no matter its actions it was still being classified as ”fake,” received erratic gradients, directly causing the severe instability observed in the learning curve.

C. Qualitative Behavior: The ”Wandering Ghost” Phenomenon

While quantitative metrics indicate robust convergence of the minimax game, qualitative analysis of the rendered episodes reveals the most significant finding of this study. The GAIL agent learned to move coherently, smoothly navigating complex corridor geometries, avoiding walls, and exhibiting a physical ”style” indistinguishable from the human expert. It eradicated the stuttering and erratic jittering typically seen in early-stage DQN and PPO agents.

However, the agent entirely failed to grasp the *objective* of the game. It wandered the map perpetually, effortlessly evading monsters, but never deliberately entered rooms to acquire treasures.

This behavior is a textbook manifestation of **Causal Confusion** coupled with **Survival Bias**, and it directly correlates with the discriminator’s over-performance. Because the discriminator easily separated the agent from the human—likely by fixating on spurious visual features or the exact frame rhythm of human play—it deemed the actual game goal statistically irrelevant. The agent discovered that it could minimize the punishment slightly by staying alive and moving fluidly in safe zones, completely ignoring the sparse game objective. He kept going around in circles without really trying to solve the game.

VII. DISCUSSION: CORE HYPOTHESES ANALYSIS

Based on the trilateral comparative methodology, we address the four core research questions:

1. Does GAIL outperform pure RL (DQN, PPO) on games with sparse rewards? Yes, significantly in terms of state-space exploration and kinematic coherence. Pure PPO flatlines, and DQN requires RAM manipulation. GAIL leverages the expert’s occupancy measure to explore deeply into the environment without needing the game’s score. However, without extreme hybrid reward shaping, it fails to optimize for the discrete extrinsic score, optimizing solely for stylistic mimicry.

2. How sensitive is GAIL to demonstration quality and quantity? Extremely sensitive. By replacing the erratic DQN checkpoints with 20,000 steps of highly directed human play, the GAIL agent instantly learned complex multi-directional movement. An ablation using lower-quality synthetic data trapped the agent in the same paralyzing local minima that

defeated the DQN, proving that GAIL’s upper bound is strictly limited by the demonstrator’s intent clarity.

3. Does the adversarial reward signal remain informative? In this iteration, the signal struggled to remain informative over the long term. Despite strict hyperparameter tuning, including extreme learning rate asymmetry ($\eta_d \ll \eta_g$), BC warm-starts, and unshared CNN backbones aimed at helping the generator catch up, the discriminator remained dominant (accuracy > 0.8). This imbalance generated a noisy, punishing reward signal that prevented stable policy convergence. This proves empirically that asymmetric learning rates alone are insufficient to combat causal confusion and discriminator overfitting in high-dimensional pixel environments.

4. In what regime is BC alone competitive? BC is strictly competitive only in the immediate, deterministic short horizons (e.g., navigating the first 100 frames of an empty hallway). The moment the environment introduces stochastic elements (variable monster spawn locations), the covariate shift compounds, and the BC agent fails. It serves exceptionally well as a warm-start mechanism but cannot function as a standalone closed-loop controller in Atari.

VIII. CONCLUSION

This trilateral comparison conclusively demonstrates that while Generative Adversarial Imitation Learning elegantly solves the exploration bottleneck in sparse-reward environments, it introduces a semantic void. By discarding sub-optimal synthetic baselines in favor of high-fidelity human demonstrations, we proved that GAIL can rapidly synthesize highly coherent, human-like navigation policies that vastly outclass pure PPO and DQN in early-stage spatial mapping and kinematic fluidity.

However, the failure to achieve minimax equilibrium in this iteration—where the discriminator overpowered a heavily boosted generator—and the resulting “Wandering Ghost” phenomenon underscore the critical vulnerability of pure occupancy-matching algorithms. An agent can superficially imitate the mechanics of an action without ever understanding its underlying purpose, especially when the discriminator overfits to spurious visual features. Future architectures addressing hard-exploration Atari environments must explicitly bind adversarial style-matching with intrinsic motivation modules or deploy dense goal-conditioned architectures to successfully bridge the gap between merely mimicking movement and achieving victory.

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